
The Staged Approach — Following the Priesthood Line

Your plan, in order, for taking Milk Before Meat from “an idea Cameron has” to “a small, blessed local test.” The whole strategy is to honor the order of the priesthood: go to your brethren first, gather their understanding and goodwill, and arrive at the Bishop already supported — so he is not the first person hearing it cold, and so what you bring him already carries the quiet endorsement of his Elders Quorum President and a member of his own bishopric.

WHY THIS ORDER WORKS

You are doing something wise and respectful: you are not going over anyone’s head or springing a finished thing on the Bishop. You are walking it up the line the way the Lord organizes His Church — peer brethren first, then a counselor in the bishopric, then the Bishop himself. By the time it reaches him, two men he trusts have already said “Cameron’s heart is right and this is worth a look.” That changes the whole feel of the conversation from “evaluate this stranger’s project” to “bless something your brethren already believe in.”

One principle to carry through every conversation: **bring it as a question, not a pitch.** “I’ve been working on something and I’d value your eyes on it” opens a door. “I’ve built something amazing and I need your approval” puts people on their heels. You want their counsel, genuinely — and you’ll often get better ideas than you walked in with.

STEP 1 — RICH SUTHERLAND (ELDERS QUORUM PRESIDENT)

Why him first: He’s a peer-level priesthood leader who presides over the brethren, he likely knows you well, and his support is natural to seek for a member’s ministering effort. He is the lowest-pressure, most natural first conversation.

What you’re asking for: Not approval to launch — just his understanding of your plan and his blessing to take it to the Bishop. You want him to say, “That sounds good, take it to the Bishop, and you can tell him I think it’s worth looking at.”

How to open it: > “Rich, can I get your thoughts on something? I’ve been building a faith app over the last while — it’s patterned on how the Savior ministered, meeting people where they are and pointing them to Christ. I’m not trying to make it some big official thing; I want to do it the right way and through the right channels. Before I ever take it to the Bishop, I wanted to run it past you and get your honest read, and ideally your blessing to bring it to him.”

What to show him: The Bishop Brochure (the one-pager). Walk him through it in two minutes. Let him hold it.

What to ask him for at the end: > “Would you be comfortable if I told the Bishop you’ve seen it and you think it’s worth his time? And is there anything you’d change about how I bring it to him?”

If he hesitates: Don’t push. Ask what gives him pause, listen, and take it seriously. His hesitation is data that will help you when you reach the Bishop. Thank him either way.

STEP 2 — KYLE CASTLE (SECOND COUNSELOR IN THE BISHOPRIC — AND YOUR CLOSE FRIEND)

Why him second: He sits *in* the bishopric, so his support carries directly into the room you ultimately care about — and he’s your friend, so he’ll be honest with you about how the Bishop is likely to react. He can also coach you on

timing (“don’t bring it up the Sunday of tithing settlement,” that kind of thing) and on the Bishop’s particular temperament.

What you’re asking for: Two things — his honest gut read as a friend, and his read as a member of the bishopric on how best to approach the Bishop. If he’s willing, having him mention it to the Bishop informally beforehand (“Cameron’s got something thoughtful he wants to show you”) is worth a great deal.

How to open it: > “Kyle, I want your honest take, both as my friend and because you’re in the bishopric. I’ve built this faith app — here’s the short version [hand him the brochure]. Rich has already seen it and is supportive. I want to bring it to the Bishop the right way, and I figured you’d know better than anyone how to do that without it landing wrong. What am I not seeing?”

What to ask him for at the end: > “Would you be willing to give the Bishop a heads-up that I’ve got something I’d like ten minutes to show him? And when you think about how he’ll react — what’s the one thing I should make sure I say, and the one thing I should make sure I *don’t* say?”

Lean on the friendship honestly here. Kyle is the person who can tell you the unvarnished truth about how this will land. Let him. If he says “honestly, I don’t think the Bishop will go for X,” that’s a gift — it lets you adjust before the meeting that matters most.

STEP 3 — THE BISHOP

Why last, and why now you’re ready: By the time you sit down with him, two priesthood leaders he trusts have already vetted both you and the idea. You arrive supported, not cold. You also arrive calm, because you’ve already heard the hard questions from Rich and Kyle and you know your honest answers.

What you’re actually asking for — be precise about this: You are *not* asking him to endorse the app, to vouch for it to the stake, or to call it a Church product. You are asking for something much smaller and very reasonable: **his blessing for you, as a member, to invite a few trusted priesthood holders in the ward to quietly test it and give you feedback.** That’s it. That’s the whole ask for this meeting. Keeping the ask small makes it easy to say yes to.

How to open it: > “Bishop, thank you for the time. I’ve built something as a member — a faith app patterned on how the Savior ministered — and I’ve already shown it to Rich and to Kyle, who encouraged me to bring it to you. I want to be really clear about what I’m and am not asking: I’m not asking the Church to endorse it, and it’s not an official Church product — it says so plainly every time it opens. I’m only asking for your blessing to let a few priesthood holders test it for a couple of weeks and tell me honestly what they think. I’d value your counsel on all of it.”

Then hand him the brochure and let him read. Don’t fill the silence. Let him take it in.

The questions he’s most likely to ask — and your one-line honest answers (the full versions are in the FAQ document):

- “*Is this an official Church thing?*” — “No, and it says so every time it opens. It’s an independent app I made as a member.”
- “*Is it okay to use AI for this?*” — “The Handbook’s new AI guidance from December says to use AI in uplifting ways that point people to God and never replace Him — and the app is built exactly that way. It tells people every time that it’s not God and can’t answer a prayer, and to go pray to Him directly.”
- “*Could it teach wrong doctrine?*” — “That’s the honest risk with any AI, and it’s exactly why I want priesthood holders testing it and flagging anything off. By default it only ministers from the Bible and never brings up the

Restoration unless the person asks and gives permission. Nothing is presented as official doctrine.”

- “*Are you trying to trick people into the Church?*” — “No. It never hides what it is — if anyone asks who made it, it says immediately that members of the Church did. It just doesn’t open with a sales pitch, the same way the Savior didn’t open with ‘I am the Messiah.’ And it lets everyone walk away free.”

What to ask for at the very end: > “Would you be comfortable with me inviting a few priesthood holders to test it? And after a couple weeks, if it sits well with you, would you be open to me sending them a simple invitation to help? I’ll send you that exact invitation first so you can see every word before it goes out.”

Offer him the first spot: If he has an iPhone or Android, offer to put it on his own phone so he can try it himself for a day or two before deciding. Nothing builds confidence like holding the thing. (The install steps are in the Install Guide — it’s genuinely a two-minute setup either way.)

AFTER THE BISHOP SAYS YES

Don’t rush. Give him (and ideally Rich and Kyle) a few days actually using it. Then, with his go-ahead, send the pre-written invitation email (next document) to the priesthood holders — and send the Bishop that exact email first, so he sees every word before anyone else does. That single courtesy — “you’ll see it before they do” — is what keeps his trust through the whole rollout.

RECRUITING YOUR 12 TESTERS — THE OFFICIAL 2-WEEK PHASE

Once the Bishop has blessed it, you move from “approval” to “gathering.” The goal of this stage is to get at least **12 people to install the app and keep it for 14 days straight** — because that is the literal rule Google requires before the app can go public. (Plain-English explanation of why: see [07_Plain-English-Map.md](#).)

The beautiful part is that this requirement makes your invitation honest and exciting at the same time. You’re not asking people for a vague favor — you’re asking them to be one of the official testers a real launch depends on.

How to gather them, without it feeling like a sales pitch:

“I built a faith app, and it’s in the official testing phase — the step right before it goes public. Do you have an Android? If you give me your email, I can add you as an official tester. Google actually needs a group of real people using it for two weeks before it can launch, so you’d be in from the very beginning and genuinely helping it get off the ground.”

Everything in that is true, and the only thing you need back is a “yes” and an email. That email is what lets the app be added to their phone as a tester.

A few things to keep it smooth:

- Don’t quiz people on their phone brand first — get them interested, *then* ask “do you have an Android?” If they have an iPhone it’s even easier: the app is live on the public App Store, so they just scan the QR or tap the link — no invite needed. Android is the one where you collect the email.
- Reassure them it’s not a timed trial — once it’s on their phone, it stays. Nothing kicks them off after two weeks. (The 14 days is Google’s behind-the-scenes counter, not a clock on their screen.)

- Hand me the emails (or a list) and I set up the closed-test track, generate the invite link, and push the build. You don't touch the console.
 - Family and friends can go first, before the ward, to warm up the list and work out any wrinkles.
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THE THROUGHLINE, IN ONE SENTENCE

Go to your brethren first, ask for counsel rather than approval, keep every ask small and honest, never hide what the app is, and let the Bishop see every word before it goes wider — and you'll have done this the Lord's way, which is the only way worth doing it.